

Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

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Abstract

Sociologists have long debated the nature of “good” and “bad” taste, yet how lay individuals implicitly define these categories remains understudied. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF) to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions. I identify four distinct cultural models for “good taste” (Shared Taste, Cultivated Discernment, Personal Style, Aesthetic Curation) and “bad taste” (Relational Distance, Questionable Consumption, Lack of Refinement, Aesthetic Neglect). Chi-square cross-tabulations demonstrate that these models align into coherent, overarching cultural logics linking positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, multinomial analyses show that these models are systematically patterned by socio-demographic factors, particularly gender and age. Finally, domain-mapping heatmaps across 19 cultural areas reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subject to taste distinctions, individuals holding aesthetic and cultivated models of bad taste exhibit a significantly higher overall propensity to draw taste boundaries across non-core domains.

1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies, operating under the assumption that individuals navigate a universally recognized landscape of legitimate culture (?). Within this paradigm, taste is primarily treated as an objective, behavioral variable—measured by attendance at classical concerts, preferences for highbrow literature, or knowledge of fine arts (?). However, this focus on the *content* of taste often neglects the *concept* of taste itself among lay individuals.¹ While recent interview-based work has begun to explore how people experience and narrate their cultural preferences (??), sociologists rarely measure how lay individuals systematically define what it actually means to have “good” or “bad” taste.

Understanding these implicit folk theories is crucial because the ways people define taste dictate the boundaries they draw around themselves and others (?). Do people view good taste as an acquired aesthetic skill that requires cultivation, a form of authentic personal self-expression, or simply a shared consensus with their immediate peers? Conversely, is bad taste defined relationally as a mismatch with the self, objectively as a lack of refinement, or morally as a passive neglect of aesthetic standards? Uncovering these cognitive schemas provides vital insight into contemporary mechanisms of symbolic boundary-drawing (?), revealing whether everyday people evaluate culture using vertical aesthetic hierarchies or horizontal relational matching (?).

To address this gap, this research note leverages computational text analysis on open-ended survey responses to inductively map the cultural models of taste held by the American public. By moving beyond predefined survey categories, this approach allows the multidimensional structure of lay taste to emerge organically from respondents’ own words (?). Furthermore, by linking these textual models to demographic variables, this study explores whether people in different positions in the social space—particularly across age and gender divides (?)—deploy fundamentally different cognitive frameworks when evaluating aesthetic worth.

2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by four primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define “good taste” and “bad taste”?
2. Do cultural models of good and bad taste form interlinked cultural logics?
3. Are these cultural models of taste systematically patterned by traditional socio-demographic hierarchies (e.g., age, gender, and education)?
4. Does the propensity to draw boundaries (the total volume of differentiated cultural domains) vary significantly depending on the underlying cultural model an individual adopts?

¹Recent work has begun to make headway on what the *analytical* concept of taste should be among sociologists (??).

3 Methods

3.1 Data

The data for this analysis are drawn from a study by ? investigating folk conceptions of aesthetic taste. The original authors recruited a representative sample of the US population through the online participant platform Prolific Academic, compensating respondents £2.38 for their participation. A total of 297 individuals initially completed the survey. In accordance with data quality protocols, 56 respondents were excluded for failing to pass four embedded attention checks. This yielded a final analytic sample of 241 participants ($M_{age} = 44.92, SD = 16.12$; 124 men, 114 women, and 3 identifying as ‘other’). For demographic modeling, missing ages and unrealistic outliers (under 18) were safely dropped listwise. Additionally, to prevent model separation due to small sample sizes, extreme upper bounds of education (PhDs) were collapsed into a general graduate degree category, while parent’s education was dropped from the final models due to structural missingness (85% missing data owing to a survey skip logic error).

The survey instrument asked respondents whether they generally distinguish between good and bad taste via the following prompt: *“When we speak of people’s preferences about works of art (such as novels, paintings, music, songs, movies, TV shows, etc.), we sometimes make a difference between people who have ‘good taste’ and those who have ‘bad taste’. Has it ever happened to you to say or think that a certain person had better taste than another one in this sense?”* Those who answered affirmatively were then prompted to provide open-ended textual definitions via the questions: *“What do you mean when you say that someone has good taste? Please, explain in a few sentences.”* and *“What do you mean when you say that someone has bad taste? Please, explain in a few sentences.”* These open-access, publicly available responses serve as the primary corpus for the present computational analysis.

3.2 Text Analysis

Among the 241 participants, 224 (93%) indicated that they make a distinction between good and bad taste and thus provided open-ended definitions. These definitions were generally brief but highly informative. For “good taste,” responses averaged 170.15 characters in length ($SD = 90.41$, range: 26–469). For “bad taste,” definitions were slightly shorter, averaging 155.83 characters ($SD = 89.78$, range: 18–647). Combined, the average participant contributed 325.98 total characters of textual data ($SD = 166.99$, range: 45–899).

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter “documents”), I used *Non-Negative Matrix Factorization (NMF)*. NMF is a linear-algebraic technique that reduces high-dimensional text data into a lower-dimensional set of latent “topics” that are seen as generative of the word choices in each document (??). This approach has been found to be particularly effective for clustering short documents (??), such as the ones considered here, which consist of just a few sentences per respondent. First, the raw text was converted into an $N \times M$ Document-Term Matrix (V), where N is the number of documents and M is the size of the vocabulary. The values in this matrix were computed using Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF), which weights words by how frequently they appear in a specific document while discounting words that are overwhelmingly com-

mon across the entire corpus. Specifically, the TF-IDF weight for a term t in a document d within a corpus D is calculated as:

$$\text{TF-IDF}(t, d, D) = \text{tf}(t, d) \cdot \log \left(\frac{N}{|\{d \in D : t \in d\}|} \right) \quad (1)$$

Where $\text{tf}(t, d)$ is the raw count of term t in document d , and the logarithmic term represents the inverse document frequency. Within this logarithmic term, N is the total number of documents, and the denominator $|\{d \in D : t \in d\}|$ is the absolute count of documents within the entire corpus that contain the term t at least once. This ensures that terms appearing in nearly every document receive a weight close to zero, highlighting only the specific lexical signals that distinguish sub-populations. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., “good,” “bad,” “taste,” “don’t”) and standard English stop words were removed.

The NMF algorithm then approximates V by factoring it into two lower-rank, strictly non-negative matrices: W and H (such that $V \approx WH$). The W matrix (size $N \times K$) represents the document-topic associations, providing a continuous “soft-assignment” weight of how strongly each respondent’s answer aligns with each of the K latent cultural models. The H matrix (size $K \times M$) represents the topic-term associations, indicating the relative importance of each vocabulary word in defining a given cultural model. The algorithm was optimized for each of the two text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring.

Finally, to explore the structural relationships between the documents and the derived topics, I conducted a Correspondence Analysis (CA) of the rectangular $N \times K$ soft-assignment matrix of document-to-topic probabilities generated by the NMF (with a minimal constant added to prevent division-by-zero errors), visualizing the geometric distance between respondents’ linguistic choices across the topics. To ensure our topic solutions were empirically robust, we evaluated NMF models across a range of component configurations (K). The optimal configuration balances two competing demands: maximizing the granularity of semantic clusters while minimizing reconstruction error. We optimized for a 4-topic solution for both Good Taste and Bad Taste. This configuration prevents the model from collapsing into overly generic models while maintaining distinct qualitative variation.

4 Results

4.1 Sample Characteristics

Before detailing the cultural models, Table ?? provides the descriptive statistics for the socio-demographic variables utilized in the demographic models. The analytic sample ($N = 219$ respondents who provided valid age and gender data alongside open-text responses) is relatively balanced by gender, skews slightly liberal politically (mean of 3.24 on a 1-7 scale, where lower values correspond to liberal ideology), and possesses high levels of educational attainment, with over half the sample holding a college or graduate degree.

Variable	Mean / %	SD	Range
Numeric Variables			
Age	44.37	15.90	[19, 80]
Political Ideology (1-7)	3.24	1.89	[1, 7]
Categorical Variables			
Gender: Man	52.1%	-	-
Gender: Woman	47.9%	-	-
Education: High School	14.2%	-	-
Education: Some College	27.4%	-	-
Education: College Degree	43.4%	-	-
Education: Graduate Degree	15.1%	-	-

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics of Socio-Demographic Variables in Multinomial Models ($N = 219$)

4.2 Cultural Models of Taste

Figure ?? and Figure ?? display the top ten most distinguishing terms (weighted by their NMF prominence) associated with each model, while Figure ?? shows the sample prevalence of each model. As shown in the term bar plots, the models are anchored by distinct lexical signatures that reveal different conceptualizations of aesthetic boundary-drawing.

For *Good Taste*, four primary cultural models emerged from the NMF analysis: *Shared Taste* (highlighting subjective similarity, driven by terms like “similar,” “say,” and “usually”), *Cultivated Discernment* (focusing on elevated aesthetic appreciation and driven by words like “art,” “quality,” and “appreciate”), *Personal Style* (emphasizing visual presentation and curation, characterized by words like “look,” “appealing,” and “clothing”), and *Aesthetic Curation* (centering on innate aesthetic stylishness via terms like “pleasing,” “aesthetically,” and “choices”). Table ?? and Table ?? present the term arrays and representative qualitative quotes for these models.

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	46	Shared Taste	similar, say, usually, likes, opinion, interests, certain...
1	99	Cultivated Discernment	art, appreciate, quality, enjoy, food, way, style...
2	39	Personal Style	look, appealing, clothing, way, knows, pick, listen...
3	40	Aesthetic Curation	pleasing, choices, aesthetically, make, stylish, typically, ...

Table 2: Good Taste Def Summary

For *Bad Taste*, respondents defined it through four distinct cultural models that mirror and invert the positive models: *Relational Distance* (emphasizing subjective differences and disagreement via words like “likes,” “different,” and “opinion”), *Questionable Consumption* (focusing on perceived poor choices in domains like music and clothing), *Lack of Refinement* (centering on low quality, cheapness, or ugliness), and *Aesthetic Neglect* (highlighting gaudiness, clashing styles, and a general lack of care in appearance or curation, anchored by words

Topic	Name	Representative Document
0	Shared Taste	“I’d say a person has good taste if I like similar things.”
1	Cultivated Discernment	“People who enjoy the same type of books or movies or art. Though I can understand someone may have exceptional taste, I don’t agree with it. Such as enjoying Rothko’s art or Wharton’s novels. ”
2	Personal Style	“Something that they like has an appealing look”
3	Aesthetic Curation	“Their choices are aesthetically pleasing to me. ”

Table 3: Representative Quotes for Good Taste Cultural Models

like “care,” “really,” and “look”). Table ?? and Table ?? present the corresponding term summaries and representative quotes.

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	62	Relational Distance	likes, different, opinion, say, art, dislike, interests...
1	66	Questionable Consumption	choices, music, clothing, preferences, shows, food, unappeal...
2	50	Lack of Refinement	usually, quality, ugly, poor, way, likes, looks...
3	46	Aesthetic Neglect	care, really, look, colors, items, gaudy, know...

Table 4: Bad Taste Def Summary

Topic	Name	Representative Document
0	Relational Distance	“When I say that someone has bad taste, it means that in my opinion, the things that person likes is very different from the things I like, so, therefore, they have bad taste.”
1	Questionable Consumption	“Someone who has bad taste in clothing choices, music, food, dating preferences. ”
2	Lack of Refinement	“Usually it is about gaining noteriety at the expense of quality. It is a the immature desire tp shock others in negative ways and usually means poor quality.”
3	Aesthetic Neglect	“Someone who has bad taste doesn’t really care or even notice how an object is made. It could be junky and poorly finished. This is like an old dented car that was painted by a kid with a spray can of some garish color paint.”

Table 5: Representative Quotes for Bad Taste Cultural Models

4.3 Internal Differentiation in Cultural Models

The CA analysis of the document-topic soft-assignment matrix allows us to explore the internal differentiation between cultural models of good and bad taste. The results for good taste are shown in Figure ?. We can see that the first dimension opposes the Personal Style and Aesthetic Curation models (on the right) to shared taste and Cultivated Discernment (on the left). The second dimension, by contrast, opposes the Aesthetic Curation (on the bottom) model against the Shared Taste and Personal Style models (on the top). Figure ? shows the

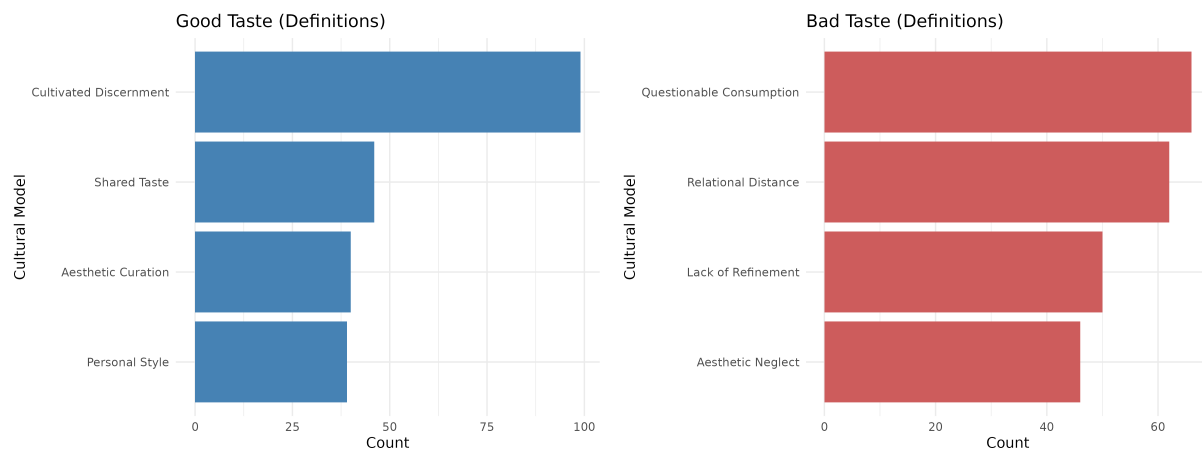


Figure 1: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

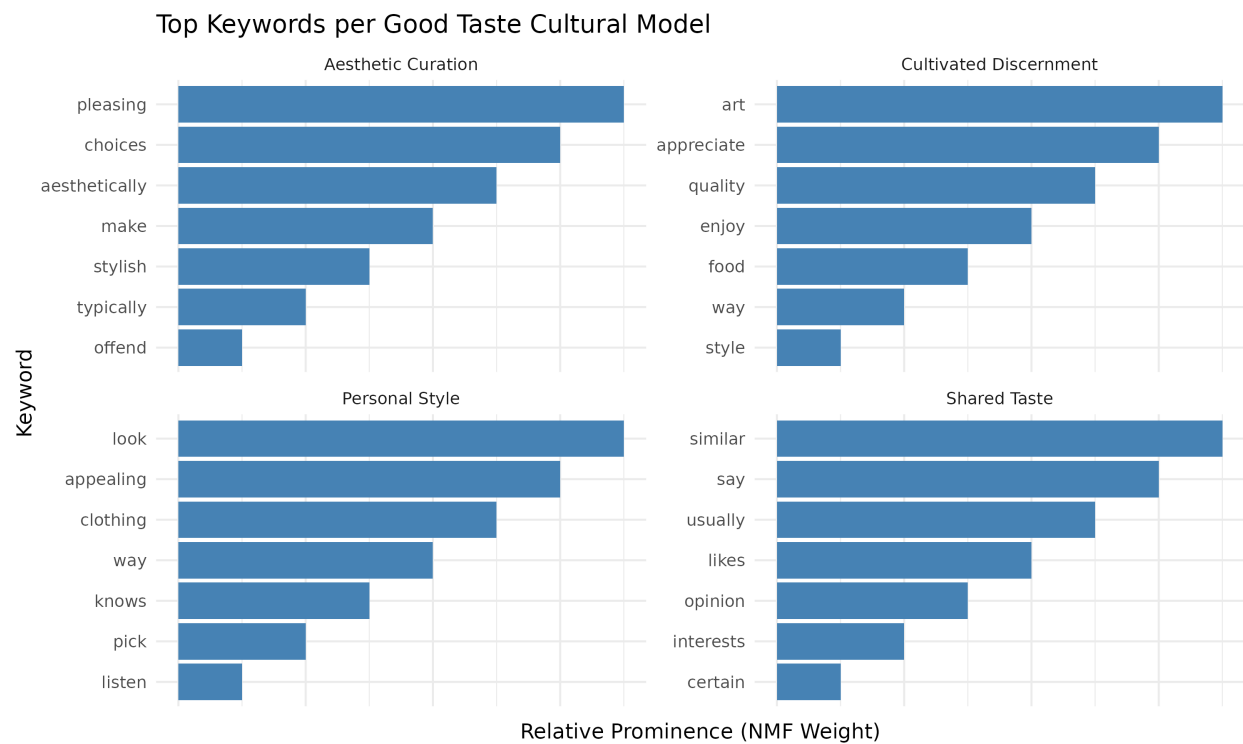


Figure 2: Top Keywords for Good Taste Cultural Models

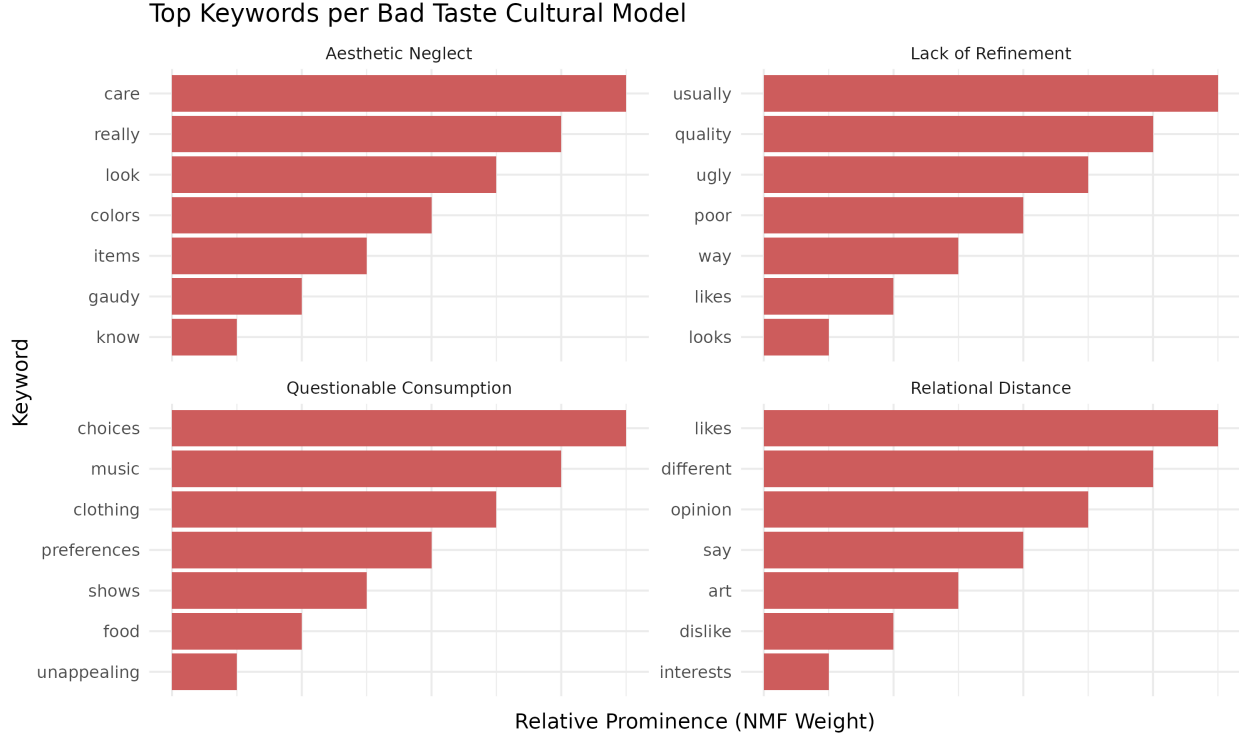


Figure 3: Top Keywords for Bad Taste Cultural Models

CA biplot for the cultural models of bad taste. We can see that the main dimension simply opposes the Aesthetic Neglect model, one of the most explicitly judgmental (on the right), to the others (on the left). The second dimension, by contrast, opposes the Questionable Consumption model (on the bottom) to the Lack of Refinement and Relational Distance Models (on the top).

4.4 Cross-Cultural Model Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent “logics,” I cross-tabulated respondents’ primary cultural models across the two questions. The two-way association between the variables is statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 20.88, p < 0.05$), suggesting that respondents who align by cultural models of good taste are non-randomly distributed in their choice of model of bad taste. Specifically, individuals who define good taste as subjective similarity (*Shared Taste*) are statistically more likely to define bad taste as subjective difference (*Relational Distance*). These same individuals, however, are much less likely to define bad taste in terms of self-similarity. Likewise, individuals whose good taste definition is focused on aesthetics (*Aesthetic Curation*) are likely to define bad taste through the lens of specific choices in cultural goods and experiences (*Questionable Consumption*). Interestingly, the Lack of Refinement definition of bad taste and the Personal Style definition of good taste seem to be standalone models, statistically unrelated to the other models.

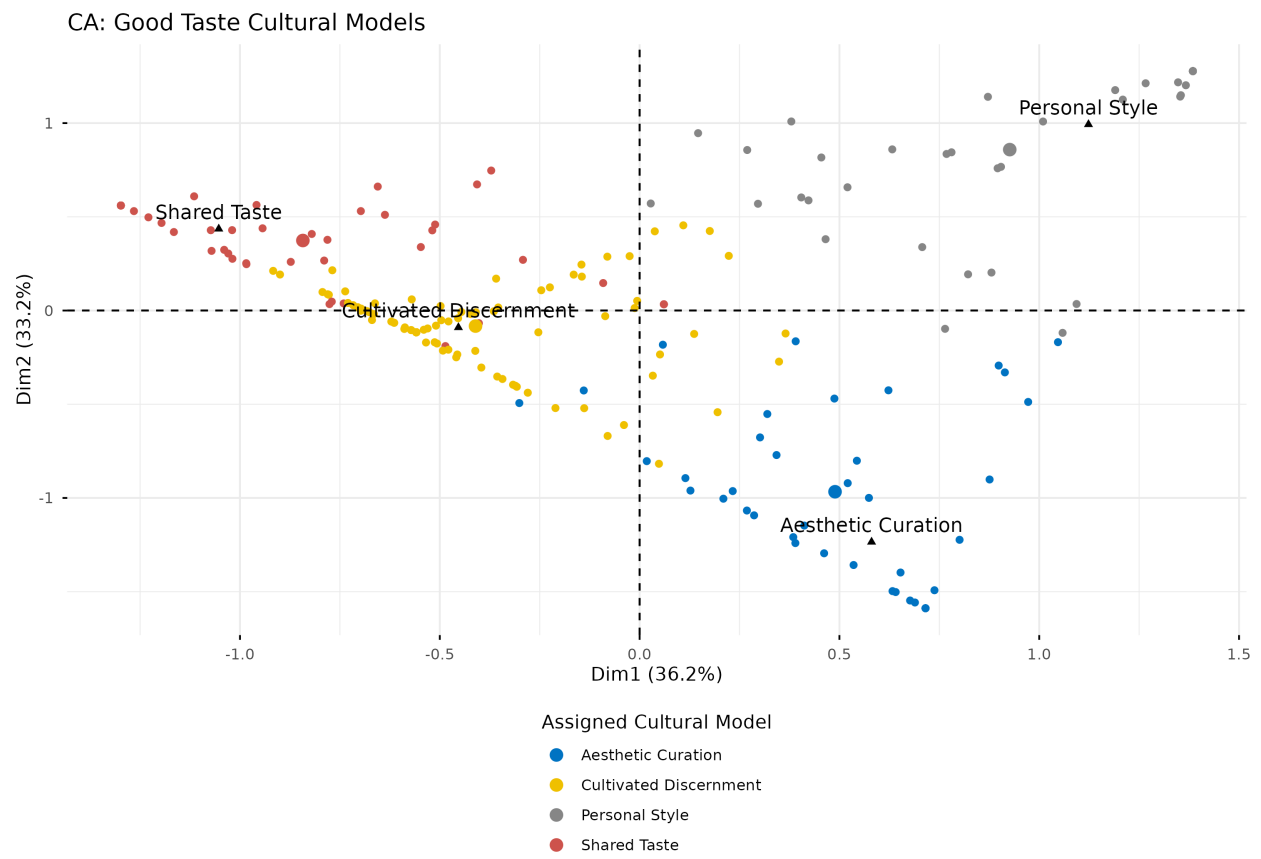


Figure 4: Correspondence Analysis of Good Taste Cultural Models (Definitions)

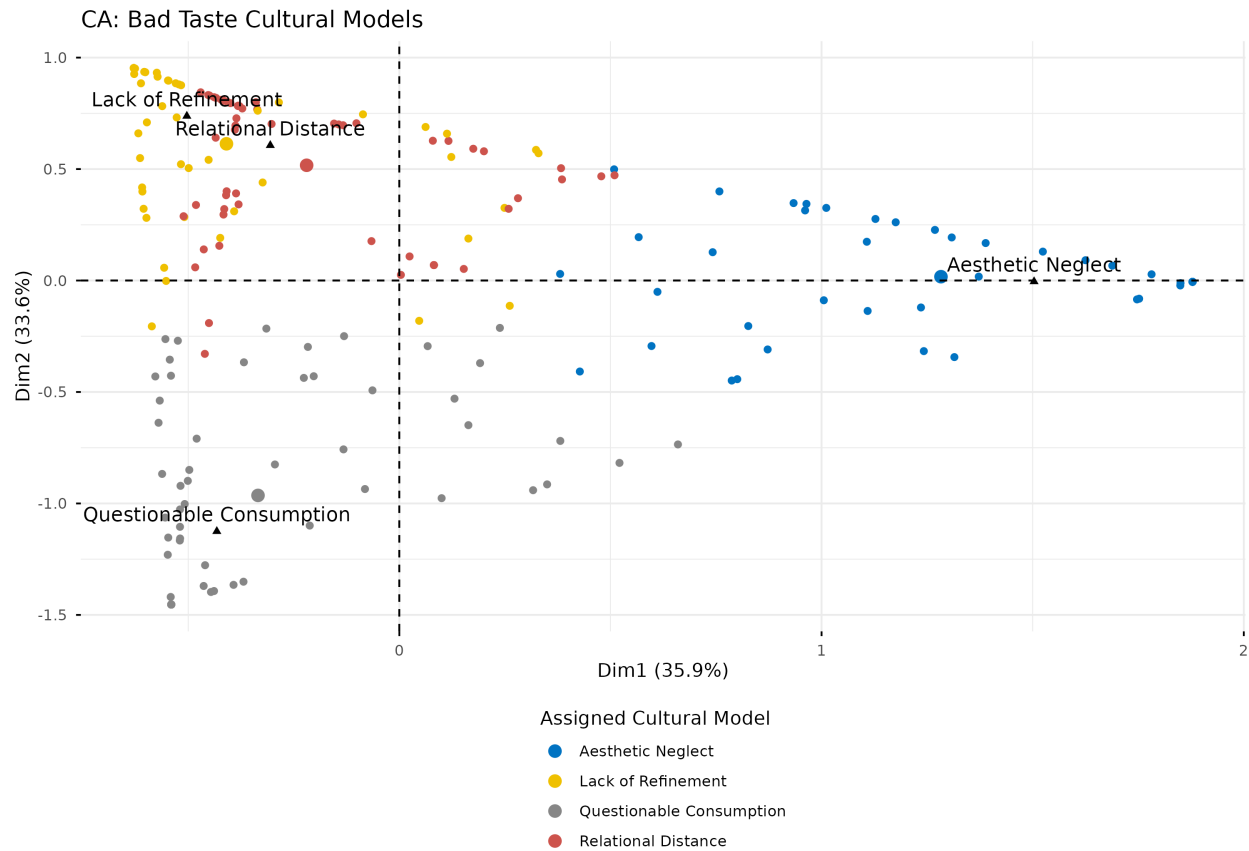


Figure 5: Correspondence Analysis of Bad Taste Cultural Models (Definitions)

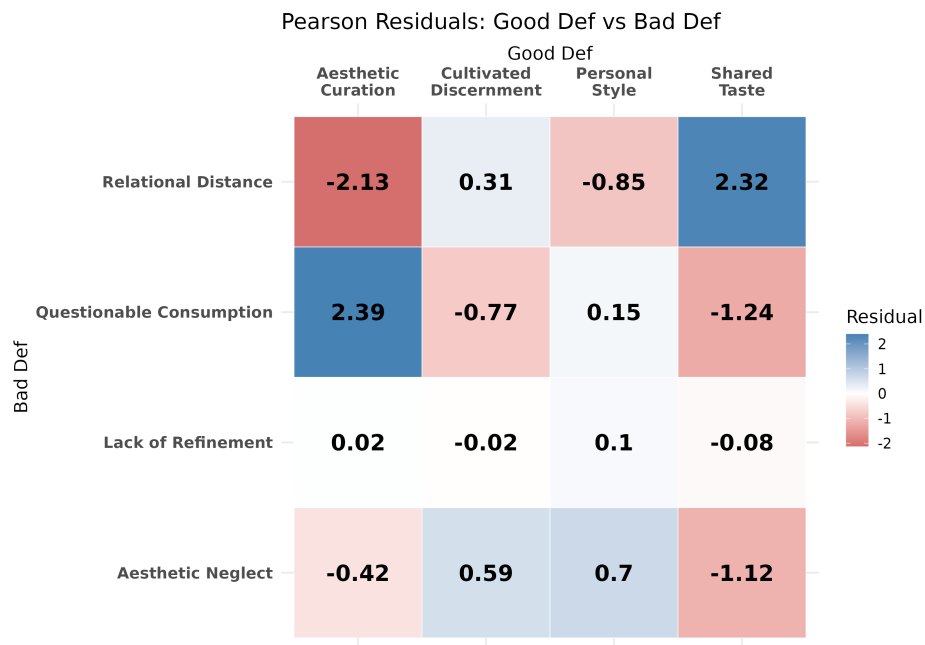


Figure 6: Pearson Residuals: Cross-Tabulation of Good and Bad Taste Cultural Models

4.5 Demographics

To examine whether taste cultural models are patterned by socio-demographic factors, I fit multinomial logistic regression models predicting respondents’ primary topic cultural model using Age, Gender, Education Level, and Political Orientation. The Likelihood Ratio χ^2 tests are presented in Table ???. As shown in Table ??, sociodemographic background structures how respondents conceptualize good and bad taste. For the Good Taste models, Age ($p \approx 0.05$) and Gender ($p < 0.05$) are significant predictors. The pattern is even stronger for Bad Taste models, where both Age ($p < 0.01$) and Gender ($p < 0.05$) significantly predict topic assignment. Education and Political Ideology did not reach statistical significance in these models, suggesting that generational cohorts and gender play a more discernible role than formal educational attainment in shaping folk definitions of taste, a surprising finding from a more traditional cultural capital perspective (?).

Model	Predictor	LR χ^2	Df	p -value
Good Taste Def	Age (Polynomial)	12.44	6	0.0528
Good Taste Def	Gender	8.62	3	0.0348
Good Taste Def	Education Level	8.62	9	0.4729
Good Taste Def	Political Ideology	1.50	3	0.6832
Bad Taste Def	Age (Polynomial)	21.93	6	0.0012
Bad Taste Def	Gender	9.47	3	0.0236
Bad Taste Def	Education Level	11.93	9	0.2175
Bad Taste Def	Political Ideology	3.73	3	0.2917

Table 6: Multinomial Logistic Regression Likelihood Ratio Tests for Topic Predictors

To unpack these statistically significant effects, I generated predicted probabilities with 95% confidence intervals for both age and gender, holding other variables constant. Figure ?? and Figure ?? display the age trajectories for Good and Bad Taste models. The Figures show that a clear generational divide emerges.

When it comes to definitions of Good Taste (Figure ??), we can see that older respondents are significantly more likely to use an *Aesthetic Curation* cultural model, emphasizing the aesthetically pleasing aspects of cultural choices. Meanwhile, middle-aged respondents are more likely to use a *Shared Tastes* cultural model, emphasizing affinity with personal preferences, than younger and older respondents.

Figure ?? shows that when it comes to cultural models of *bad* taste, younger respondents are significantly more likely to conceptualize bad taste subjectively and relationally (e.g., using the *Relational Distance Model*), whereas older adults shift heavily toward objective, aesthetic judgments, overwhelmingly defining bad taste as a *Lack of Refinement* or as *Questionable Consumption*.

Figure ?? and Figure ?? show the predicted probabilities of using each of the cultural models of good and bad taste by gender identity. For good taste, women are significantly more likely than men to define it as a shared relational property (*Shared Taste*), while men are more likely to define it via pure aesthetics, highbrow discernment or *Aesthetic Curation*. For bad taste, men are heavily overrepresented in the *Questionable Consumption* model,

indicating a higher propensity to define bad taste simply by the consumption of the “wrong” things in specific domains like music and clothing, while women are more likely to use the *Aesthetic Neglect* model, emphasizing a lack of care for aesthetic qualities or gaudy or showy public displays.



Figure 7: Predicted Probabilities of Good Taste Models by Age (with 95% CIs)

4.6 Boundary Drawing and Domain Distinctions

To assess how broadly respondents apply their taste definitions across specific cultural domains, respondents were asked to rate whether it “makes sense” to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree). To examine possible connections between cultural models of good and bad taste and the tendency to draw aesthetic boundaries across domains, I constructed an additive variable representing the total volume of domains (out of 19) in which a respondent reported saying that someone has good or bad taste, on a scale from -3 (no sense at all) to +3 (complete sense).² A respondent was counted as agreeing that taste distinctions could be made on that domain if they scored the domain as 2 or 3.

²Each respondent was asked: “For each of the following domains, indicate whether (according to you), it makes sense to say someone has good or bad tastes in this domain.”

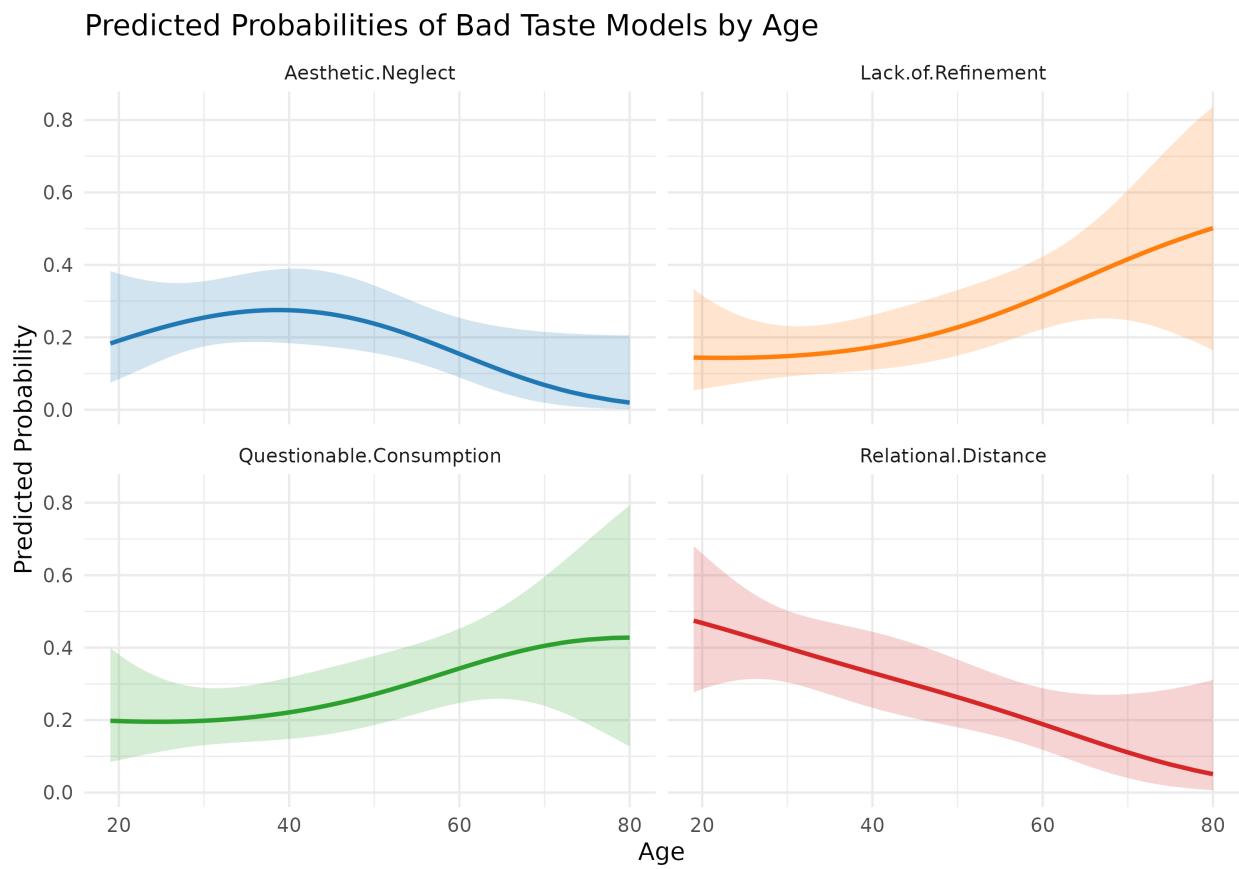


Figure 8: Predicted Probabilities of Bad Taste Models by Age (with 95% CIs)

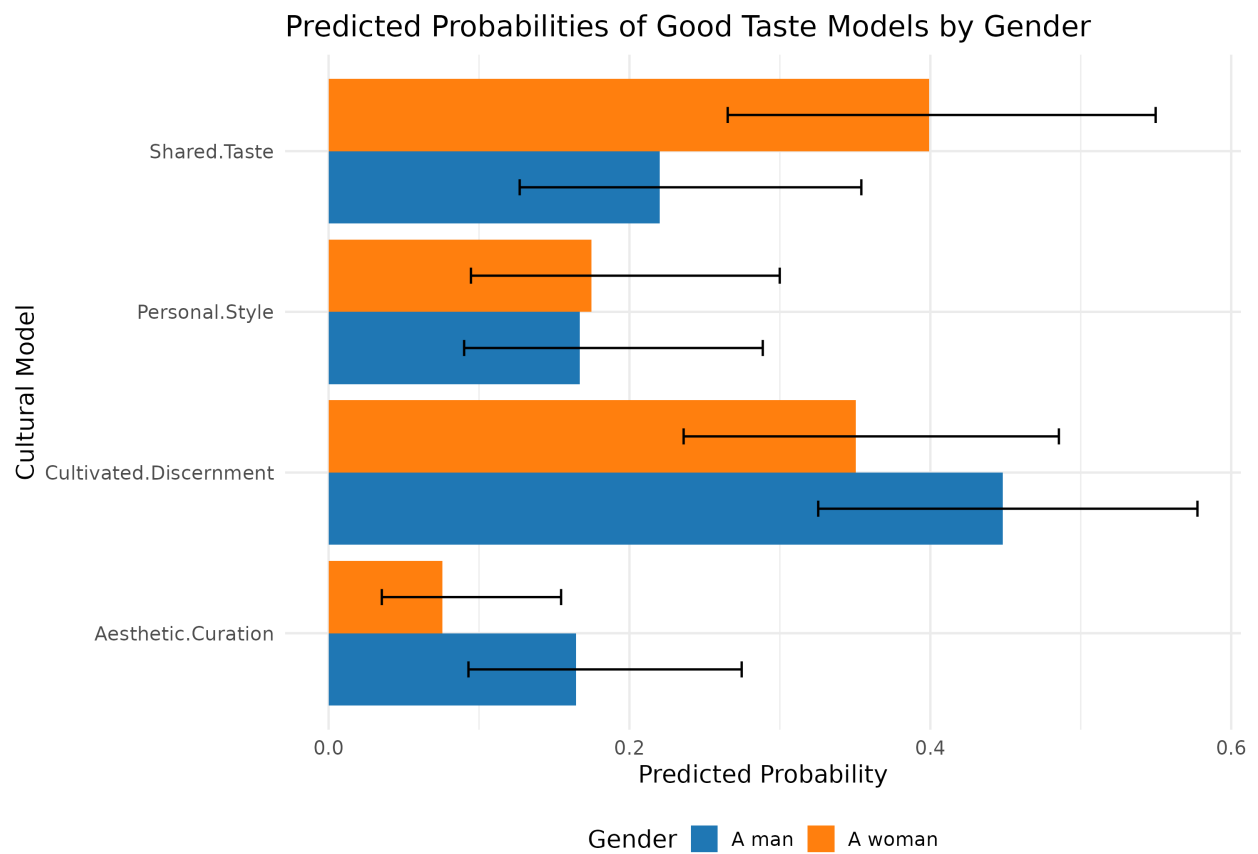


Figure 9: Predicted Probabilities of Good Taste Models by Gender

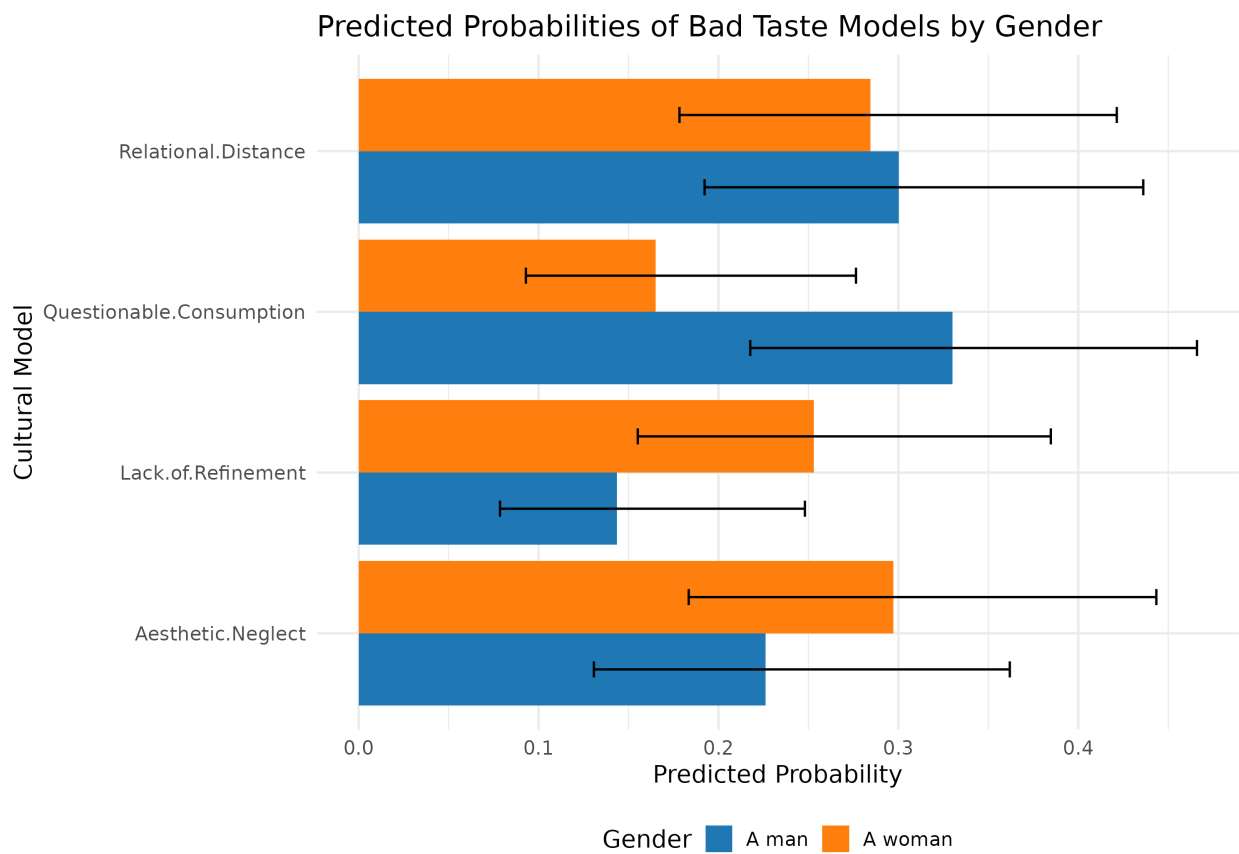


Figure 10: Predicted Probabilities of Bad Taste Models by Gender

I ran a one-way ANOVA to test whether the average number of differentiated domains varies by the respondent’s cultural model assignment. The results show that respondents operating under different cultural models differ significantly in the sheer volume of cultural spaces they subject to aesthetic differentiation. Specifically, this relationship is statistically significant for the *bad taste* cultural models (see Table ??).

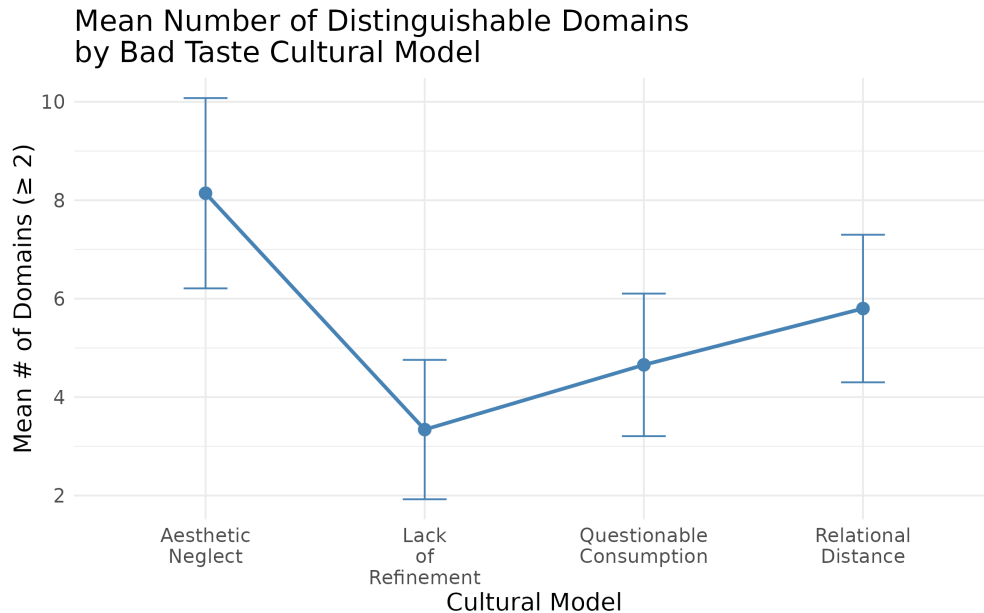


Figure 11: Mean Number of Distinguishable Domains by Bad Taste Cultural Model

Predictor	<i>F</i>	num Df	den Df	<i>p</i> -value
Good Taste Def	0.67	3	203	0.571
Bad Taste Def	5.64	3	203	0.001***

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Table 7: ANOVA Results: Number of Domains (score ≥ 2) by Taste Cultural Model.

Visualizing the specific probabilities of boundary-drawing across these 19 domains via heatmaps (Figure ??) reveals several interesting patterns. Regardless of the cultural model adopted, respondents exhibit a high likelihood of drawing taste distinctions across core lifestyle and aesthetic domains such as *Clothing*, *Interior Design*, *Movies*, *Music*, and *Paintings*. Conversely, taste distinctions are almost universally rejected for domains like *Car Races* and *Wrestling*.

Yet, there are also some suggestive differences that depend on the cultural model of bad taste adopted. Individuals who define bad taste in terms of *Aesthetic Neglect* and gaudy display are also the ones to extend the realm of aesthetic judgment into relatively non-standard domains such as beer, video games, and comic books. They thus display the most generalized version of the “aesthetic disposition” (?). Meanwhile, individuals who define bad taste in terms of *Lack of Refinement* have the most conservative approach to linking

judgments of taste to cultural domains, reserving it for the most consecrated domains, and summarily excluding non-standard domains, which fits their socio-demographic generational profile.

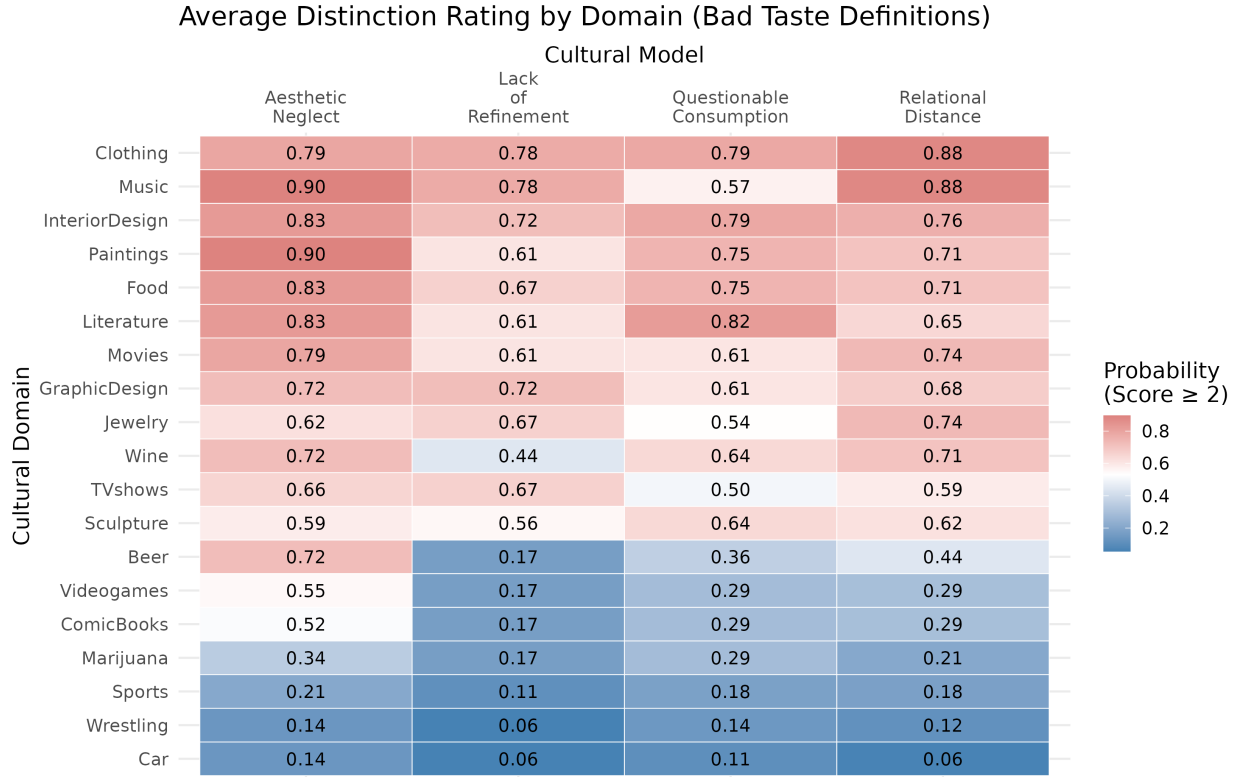


Figure 12: Probability of Making Taste Distinctions by Domain and Bad Taste Cultural Model

5 Discussion and Conclusion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; rather, they are multidimensional, spanning aesthetic, subjective, relational, and consumption-based dimensions. By leveraging computational text analysis on open-ended survey responses, this study surfaces four distinct cultural models of good taste (Shared Taste, Cultivated Discernment, Personal Style, Aesthetic Curation) and four corresponding models of bad taste (Relational Distance, Questionable Consumption, Lack of Refinement, Aesthetic Neglect).

Crucially, the correspondence analysis reveals a profound symmetry in how individuals conceptualize these symbolic boundaries. Rather than operating as disjointed concepts, good and bad taste function as mirrored cognitive schemas. An individual who defines good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria inevitably evaluates bad taste using the exact same yardstick—as a lack of aesthetic refinement rather than a relational mismatch.

5.1 Theoretical Implications

These findings carry significant theoretical implications for the sociology of culture and inequality. First, they challenge strictly top-down, Bourdieusian models that often assume a singular, universally recognized definition of legitimate taste (?). Instead, we observe a culturally fragmented landscape of “folk sociology,” where individuals hold competing lay theories of what taste actually means. Some deploy taste as a marker of highbrow aesthetic discernment, while others entirely reject objective hierarchies, viewing taste purely as a subjective mechanism for social sorting (i.e., “Shared Taste”).

Second, this study highlights that these cognitive models are deeply socially patterned, pointing to distinct generational and gendered habituses. The stark age divide—where younger adults overwhelmingly define taste subjectively and relationally, while older adults rely on objective aesthetic standards—suggests a potential macro-cultural shift in how cultural capital is deployed (?). If this is a cohort effect rather than a life-cycle effect (and we cannot yet tell using cross-sectional data), it would indicate that younger generations are retreating from universal aesthetic hierarchies in favor of localized, relational matching (?).

Furthermore, the gendered dynamics of taste definition provide new avenues for understanding the socialization of cultural consumption. Women’s higher propensity to define good taste as a shared, relational property contrasts with men’s overrepresentation in cultural models focusing on “objective” aesthetic rules or the policing of “Questionable Consumption,” suggesting a more boundary-policing, hierarchical orientation toward cultural goods.

5.2 Future Research

While this study provides a novel mapping of folk models of taste, several avenues remain for future research. Most pressing is the need to disentangle the age effects observed here: longitudinal data is required to determine whether the shift toward subjective, relational definitions of taste among the youth represents a permanent generational cohort replacement or merely a life-course phase.

Additionally, future work should bridge the gap between these cognitive models and behavioral outcomes. Do individuals who define taste as “Shared Taste” actually exhibit more homophily in their social networks (?)? Does a belief in “Cultivated Discernment” correlate with traditional measures of highbrow cultural consumption and attendance at elite arts institutions? Finally, expanding this methodology to comparative, cross-national contexts would illuminate whether these folk models of taste are specific to the contemporary American cultural landscape or reflect broader, transnational transformations in the nature of symbolic boundaries.

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